

PRE HISTORIC AGE

Origin & Divisions of History

- ❖  **Meaning**
 - ✓ Word “**History**” from Greek *historia* = “inquiry, knowledge by investigation.”
 - ✓ Study of past events shaping human experiences.
 - ❖  **Pre-History**
 - ✓ Period **before writing**.
 - ✓ Represented by **three Stone Ages** (Palaeolithic, Mesolithic, Neolithic).
 - ❖  **Proto-History**
 - ✓ Transitional phase; writing existed but **undeciphered or oral traditions**.
 - ✓ Examples:
 - ✓ **Harappan civilisation**: undeciphered script, mentioned in Mesopotamian records.
 - ✓ **Vedic civilisation (1500–600 BCE)**: oral tradition, no written texts.
 - ✓ Includes **Neolithic & Chalcolithic cultures**.
 - ❖  **History**
 - ✓ Begins **after invention of writing**.
 - ✓ Study of literate societies using **written + archaeological sources**.
 - ❖  **Key Contributors in India**
 - ✓ **Robert Bruce Foote**: Father of Indian prehistory; discovered **Polavaram hand axe** (first Palaeolithic tool in India).
 - ✓ **Sir Mortimer Wheeler**: Advanced study of prehistoric cultures & their sequence.
- ◆ Based on geological age, the type and technology of stone tools, and subsistence base, the Indian Stone Age is classified primarily into three types:

✓ **Indian Stone Age:**

A. **Old stone Age, Palaeolithic Age (5,00,000–10,000 BCE)**

B. **Late Stone Age, Mesolithic Age (10,000–6000 BCE)**

C. **New Stone Age, Neolithic Age (6,000–1000 BCE)**

Palaeolithic Age (Hunters and Food Gatherers)

- ❖ The Palaeolithic Age is the earliest period of the Stone Age, which developed in the **Pleistocene period** or the Ice Age. It was spread in practically all parts of India except the alluvial plains of the **Indus and Ganga**.
- ❖ The Palaeolithic man of India are said to have belonged to the Negrito race and lived in caves and rock shelters. They were food gathering people who lived on hunting and gathering wild fruits and vegetables.
- ❖ They had no knowledge of agriculture, house building, pottery, or any metal. It was only in later stages that they attained the knowledge of fire.
- ❖ Man, during this period, used tools of unpolished, undressed rough stones — **mainly hand axes, cleavers, choppers, blades, burin, and scrapers. Since the stone tools were made of a hard rock called ‘quartzite’,**

❖ Palaeolithic men are therefore also called ‘Quartzite men’ in India.

<u>Early or lower Palaeolithic</u>	<u>Middle Palaeolithic</u>	<u>Late or Upper Palaeolithic</u>
I. Use of hand axes, choppers, and cleavers, mainly for chopping, digging, and skinning.	I. Use of stone tools made of flakes, mainly scrapers, borers, points, and bladelike tools.	I. Parallel-sided blades, burins, and some instances of bone tools.
II. Found in Soan and Sohan river valley (now in Pakistan), Kashmir, Thar Desert (Didwana, Rajasthan), Hiran Valley (Gujarat), rockshelters of Bhimbetka (MP), and Belan Valley Mirzapur (UP)	II. Found in Soan and Sohan river valley Potwar plateau (between Indus and Jhelum), Sanghao Cave (near peshawar, Pakistan)	II. Found in Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Central MP, Southern UP and Chhotanagpur Plateau. Bone tools found only at cave sites of Kurnool and Muchchatla Chintamani Gavi in Andhra Pradesh.
III. 5,00,000 BCE–50,000 BCE	III. 50,000 BCE –40,000 BCE	III. 40,000 BCE–10,000 BCE
IV. Covers the greater part of the Ice Age.	IV. Established only in 1960 by H.D. Sankalia and was named Nevasan industry after the site of Nevasa (Maharashtra).	IV. Homo sapiens first appeared at the end of this phase. Coincided with the last phase of the Ice Age, when the climate became comparatively warm and less humid.

Mesolithic Age (Hunters and Herders)

Key Features

- **Intermediate stage** between Paleolithic & Neolithic.
- Belongs to **Holocene era** (post-Pleistocene).
- Economy: **hunting, fishing, food gathering**, later **animal domestication**.
- Tools: Smaller, refined versions of earlier stone tools.

Cultural Aspects

- **Pottery**: Rare; found at **Langhnaj (Gujarat) & Kaimur (UP)**.
- **Plant cultivation** began in later phase.
- **Rock art**: First discovered in 1867 at **Sohagighat (UP)**.
 - Over **150 sites** across India.
 - Rich concentration in **Central India (Bhimbetka, Kathotia, Jaora, Kharwar)**.
 - Other sites: **Sundargarh & Sambalpur (Odisha)**, **Ezhuthu Guha (Kerala)**.
 - Dominated by **animal depictions**; **snakes absent**.

Settlements & Finds

- **Adamgarh (M.P.), Bagor (Rajasthan)**: Earliest evidence of animal domestication.

- **South of Krishna River (Tinnevely, TN):** Mesolithic presence.
- **Birbhanpur (West Bengal):** Important site.
- **Sarai Nahar Rai (near Allahabad), Pratapgarh, Mahadaha (UP):** Bone artifacts (arrowheads, ornaments).
- **Chhotanagpur region.**
- **Bhimbetka –**
 - **Bhimbetka**, a world heritage site, in the **Raisen district** of the state of **Madhya Pradesh** is known for its **prehistoric rock shelters**.
 - It is a **UNESCO World Heritage Site** that consists of seven hills and over 10 km. It was designated so in the year **2003**.
 - Most of the credit to discover the caves goes to **Shri V.S. Vakankar**.
 - The Bhimbetka site consists of the following:
 - Palaeolithic evidence from excavations with shelters indicating the antiquity of human settlement.
 - Stone and Iron Age walls and floors within the rock shelters.
 - 400 painted rock-shelters in five clusters.
 - Forest areas around the rock paintings.
 - Most paintings are from the Mesolithic era.

Neolithic Age (Food-Producing Stage)

Significance

- Termed “**Neolithic Revolution**” by V. Gordon Childe.
- Marked the shift from hunting-gathering to **food production & settled life**.

Key Innovations

- **Agriculture:** Cultivation of crops like **ragi & horse gram**.
- **Domestication:** Cattle, sheep, goats.
- **Stone Tools:** Polished, pecked, ground tools; use of **celts** (hand axes).
- **Pottery:** Initially handmade, later wheel-made.

Tool Types by Region

- **North-Western:** Rectangular axes, curved cutting edge.
- **North-Eastern:** Polished axes with rectangular butt, occasional hoes.
- **Southern:** Axes with oval sides, pointed butt.

Major Sites & Features

- **Burzahom (J&K):** Rectangular chopper, dogs buried with masters.
- **Gufkraal (J&K):** Pit dwellings, household graveyards.
- **Maski, Brahmagiri, Piklihal, Budihal, Tekkalakota (Karnataka):** Cattle herding, communal feasting.
- **Paiyampalli (TN), Utnur (AP):** Settlements with pottery.
- **Garo Hills (Meghalaya), Chirand (Bihar):** Bone tools, antlers.
- **Saraikhola, Amri, Kotdiji, Mehrgarh (Pakistan):** Mehrgarh = earliest Neolithic, “Breadbasket of Baluchistan.”
- **Koldihwa & Mahagara (UP):** Circular huts, crude pottery, **earliest rice cultivation evidence worldwide**.
- **Chopani-Mando (Belan Valley):** Earliest pottery use.
- **Belan & Narmada Valleys:** Continuity of Paleolithic → Mesolithic → Neolithic phases.

Chalcolithic Age / Copper-Stone Age (c. 3000–500 BCE)

Key Features

- **First use of metals:** Copper (main), occasional bronze; alongside stone tools.
- **Agriculture:** Wheat, rice, bajra, pulses (lentil, black gram, green gram, grass pea).
- **Cultivation style:** Slash-and-burn (jhum); no plough/hoe evidence.
- **Animal domestication:** Cows, sheep, goats, pigs, buffaloes; hunted deer.
 - Ate beef, avoided pork; no horses.
 - Animals slaughtered for food, not milked (similar to Gond tribe today).

Pottery & Craft

- **Black-and-red pottery:** Wheel-made, painted with white designs.
- **Gender roles:** Men used potter's wheel; women made pottery by hand.
- **Ornaments:** Shell, bone, combs; fond of decoration.
- **Clay figurines:** Mother Goddess worship.
- **Bull cult:** Stylised bull terracottas (Malwa, Rajasthan).

Settlements & Lifestyle

- Small villages, mud/thatched houses; no burnt bricks.
- Village-based economy; no writing system.
- Food cooked; close-knit huts.

Burial Practices

- **Maharashtra:** North–South burials.
- **Southern India:** East–West burials.
- **Eastern India:** Fractional burials.

Major Sites & Highlights

- **Rajasthan (Ahar, Gilund):** Smelting, metallurgy, stone houses, burnt bricks.
- **Maharashtra (Nevasa, Jorwe, Navdatoli, Daimabad, Inamgaon, Nasik):**
 - Jorwe = non-Harappan culture.
 - Navdatoli = wide crop cultivation.
 - Daimabad = largest site, bronze artifacts.
 - Inamgaon = large mud houses, ovens, pit dwellings.
- **Bihar (Chirand, Senuar, Sonpur):** Rice-based settlements.
- **West Bengal (Mahishdal):** Distinct pottery.
- **M.P. (Kayatha, Malwa, Eran):** Rich ceramics, spindle whorls, non-Harappan culture.